imitation (flattery)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44107501.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by n7punk

Summary

Adora knows, when she looks in the mirror, that she doesnt look like Catra, but she doesnt think any of them really look like each other. There's so many different cadets in the horde, it takes her awhile to realize there are more differences between them than the natural difference between two people. What she does know is that it's totally unfair that Catra can purr and she cant even hear it all the time.
(Or, Adora is not a magicat and she's the only one this hasnt occurred to)

Notes

Babydora is doing her best to function with a subpar understanding of emotion and I love her for it. Sometimes she's a more unreliable narrator than Catra is. You know the phrase cute aggression? That's definitely the only way Adora knew how to process that emotion for a long time.
Hope you enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra flops on top of her as soon as they get back to their bunk. Adora lets out an *oof* as the air knocks out of her, but it does nothing to deter Catra from crushing her. In fact, Catra chuffs and wriggles to settle in further. Adora coughs back. It's the closest she can get to a chuff and it makes Catra snicker. She doesn't know why her vocal range has to be so limited compared to Catra's, but she does her best to keep up. She's figured out growling, at least. It's not the same, but it's close enough, and it deters the other kids from bothering them when it has to. She has *tried* purring – many times – but she can never manage it.

Catra, as if to rub it in her face, rumbles as she nuzzles into the sheets just beside Adora's shoulder, her cheek tufts brushing her. It's a quiet purr, the only kind she ever gives anymore because she doesn't want the other kids to hear when she's happy. She thinks they'll bully her for it or use it against her. She doesn't want to give them that kind of tactical advantage. She doesn't flop on Adora like this much anymore either. It used to be fine, but they're starting to move up into training simulations rather than just exercising together. The time for childish things like *cuddling* is supposed to be behind them.

Cuddling is nice, though. They're not going to be doing real combat sims for a while now. Cuddling can be okay when they're alone, which they basically are right now. Anybody could come back to the bunkroom, but it's the middle of the day, so she thinks they'll be okay. People don't tend to hang out here until evening, so they should be fine until after dinner. Adora hopes the twinging in her side will have gone down by then. Nothing really happened, she thinks she just overstressed it. Hopefully resting will help.

She didn't say anything, but she thinks Catra knew anyway and that's why she wanted to come back here. She's always really good on picking that stuff up. Adora wishes she could be that perceptive, but she doesn't know what Catra means when she says she can tell the difference in Adora's breathing. Unless Catra is panting, Adora isn't able to pick up her breathing at all, and she knows she wasn't

that obvious or someone else would have noticed too. No one ever notices but Catra. They're closer than anyone else in their training group, though. Maybe the familiarity is important. They already know Catra hears better than Adora.

Adora reaches up and runs her finger over the back of one of Catra's ears, the one closest to her face. Catra immediately twitches – herself and her ear – and lets out a low sound Adora hasn't heard in awhile, a *mrrp* she used to make all the time but now usually only slips out in the moment between sleep and wakefulness. Adora feels her chest flutter at the sound. She has a long list of sounds that only Catra really makes that she loves and that one has always been one of her favorites. She knows she has no hope of ever replicating it.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks, and her tone is snappy and annoyed, but Adora *knows* that's not what the little trill sound means, so she's probably just being bossy for the sake of it. She always dodges the other kids trying to pull on her ears or tail, but she likes it when Adora scratches her ears so she lets her touch them. She knows Adora won't hurt them. Adora will even let Catra grab her ear too and yank on it to be annoying, even if it's not the same. It doesn't bother Adora the way it hurts Catra, but it makes things feel more equal since no one else gets their ears pulled except occasionally Rogelio.

"Don't know. Your ears are really soft," Adora murmurs, taking a risk on doing it again. Catra's ear flicks once more, but her body doesn't twitch. She doesn't try to move away as Adora carefully pets her. She's pretty sure Catra will bite her if she pets the fur the wrong way, so she sets to gentle strokes along the length of her ears. They really are *soft*, maybe one of the softest things Adora has touched. They don't quite compare to Catra's tummy fluff, but Adora hasn't touched that in a long time. It feels weird to want to do. She doesn't think anyone else thinks about stuff like this and she's too scared to ask and find out something is wrong with her.

"You're weird," Catra accuses, but she doesn't pull away. She doesn't even twitch her ears – that much – as Adora lifts her other

hand and pets both ears at once. Adora chews on her lip. Catra doesn't seem upset at all. It's probably fine. There isn't anybody – not even Shadow Weaver – who can make Catra do something she doesn't want to do. If she wanted Adora to stop, she would have done something by now.

"I'm just thinking about them. I can't believe you heard me coming today, I was so *quiet*," Adora complains as she pets. She thought she had snuck up on Catra, but apparently there is *no* sneaking up on Catra, and she pounced before Adora could. Adora only avoided losing because Rogelio joined the fray and Catra couldn't hold them both off at once. She retreated and left Adora and Rogelio to fight instead. Rogelio is growing from the shrimp he used to be and gaining strength every day, but for now Adora was able to hold her own.

"If you think that's being sneaky, you're never going to make it to Force Captain. You'll alert every princess in the Whispering Woods when they finally let us out," Catra returns, her voice teasing as she turns her head and makes a bid to bite Adora's hand. It's not a serious attempt – if it had been, Adora probably wouldn't have been able to move in time since she wasn't paying attention – and Adora swats at Catra's ear in retaliation. Catra growls, quiet and playful. She drops her head back to the mattress without any more fuss, yawning loudly. Like a lot of things about her, Catra's yawn is cute.

"Now shut up. I want to nap before we have to go to drills," Catra tells her, already closing her eyes and settling in as if it could ever be comfortable to sleep draped across Adora nearly crosswise. Her tail sways a little as Adora settles one hand in her mane, petting slowly. Adora doesn't know why Catra got the ears and the tail and the purrs and the cute yawn, but at least she lets Adora experience them too. They really shouldn't fall asleep like this, but given the slight rumble on Catra's breath – not a purr but just enough vibration to know she *could* purr if she wanted to – Adora is pretty sure it's too late to move her.

Oh well. She can rest her side until they have to get up. She can think of worse ways to spend an afternoon.

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Adora is jealous of Catra's claws, of *course* she is. They're useful for everything from climbing to opening ration packets. Catra always has a weapon on her, always ready to fight. Anybody would be jealous of that. She's a step above a lot of the other cadets. Maybe that's why they focus on her when she's by herself. Maybe they're jealous the way Adora is, but instead of focusing on how cool Catra is all they can think about is what she has that they don't.

Catra's strong, though, and she always beats them. Or at least gets away. And she comes to Adora! She comes to her when she doesn't want to put up with the others, or when she's lonely, or just bored. She *trusts* Adora. She runs off into darkened corners with her and they wrestle, and talk, and sometimes just kind of drape over each other. It's nice. Adora gets to pet her tail while they talk about their training, or the Horde, or what they're going to do when they're finally officers and can see the world together.

Everybody who doesn't have them is jealous of Catra's claws, obviously, but Adora knows that what she feels about her ears and tail is probably less universal. She's not jealous of them, she doesn't think, even if she knows that Catra's hearing and balance is better than hers because of them. She just looks at them and they make her feel this weird violent impulse to squeeze something until it breaks. Maybe that's why she tugs on them, sometimes. She's always careful, never wanting to *hurt* Catra despite the impulse in her telling her to bear down on her, but Catra always makes a big show of indignation when she does it, scrambling away and hissing at her. Sometimes she makes a swipe at her or pounces on her in

retaliation, and then they're laughing and wrestling until the urge in Adora's chest eases and she feels like she can breathe again.

She knows she probably pays too much attention to Catra, watching her in moments and ways it doesn't even make sense to, but when she lays down and stares directly into Catra's mismatched eyes, Catra doesn't call her weird. She just slowly blinks back, relaxing her pupils so Adora can stare into deep black surrounded by the most vibrant colors she has ever seen. The concept of *pretty* isn't often relevant to combat sims or any other part of their daily lives – not many people use the word, and even fewer use the word cute, but Catra is *so cute* Adora doesn't know how she would have avoided exploding before now if she didn't have a word to put to the feeling – and she's fairly sure she's not supposed to think this regardless, but Catra is the prettiest person she's ever seen.

Right now she's watching Catra, but they aren't stretched out over Adora's bunk staring in each other's eyes this time. Catra is stretched out on one of the many catwalks in the Fright Zone, watching the skiffyard below. She has one arm dangling over the edge, on her stomach and blocking the entire path where she is laid crosswise over it. One of her legs is curled under her in a way that seems like it must be uncomfortable and her other foot dangles over the opposite end of the narrow walkway. Her tail sways back and forth as she watches the movements below with a focused disinterest Adora has never seen anyone else manage.

She doesn't watch the other kids the same way she watches Catra, but she definitely hasn't seen Lonnie be so nonchalant about something she is so clearly invested in before. Adora is stretched out next to Catra, though both her legs are straight so she can kick her feet a little over the edge. She has her arm bent so she can rest her chin – or alternatively , when that starts hurting, her cheek – on it as she looks between Catra and the yard below.

She isn't sure what's so interesting. When she tried to ask, Catra just shushed her and told her to leave if she was going to interrupt her while she was relaxing. Adora thought she might be settling in to

take a nap, even if the location is ridiculous, but so far Catra has just been lazily tracking the movement below. Her eyelids are starting to droop, though, so maybe she is going to sleep soon. Adora remembers a story one of the older cadets told about counting rats to help him sleep back when he was little. Something about picturing them carrying food back to one of their nests behind miscellaneous machinery helped him relax.

Maybe Catra is doing that, but real instead of imaginary. Her ears are twitching occasionally, something they do sometimes when she is falling asleep. Lots of things make her ears twitch, though. It's hard to know. It doesn't really matter, Adora is just occupying her thoughts while she watches Catra. She could go do something else, but she likes looking at Catra. It makes her chest warm – in a pleasant way, not like a fever.

She knows Catra is doing *something*, but she kind of wants her to look at her. Really wants her to, actually, she just knows that's weird, so *kind of* feels more appropriate. She really likes when Catra will stare back at her and her eyes get so big. She thinks it may happen just because they're close, but she's definitely seen Catra's eyes do it when there's some distance between her and her focus, so it might just be a relaxation thing. It's really cute, though, and Adora just wants to see it right now. Her own eyes can't undergo nearly as big of a change, that's just a Rogelio and Catra thing.

It's interesting when Rogelio does it, but for some reason it just isn't the same. Rogelio has a lot of the stuff that makes Catra so cool – the claws, the fangs, the tail, even the eyes a little bit, though Rogelio's aren't quite as cool as Catra's – but *he* isn't the same. Catra's just cool and it isn't all down to how she looks. Adora doesn't lay down with Rogelio and people watch, but she's happy to spend their next free hour doing nothing much at all if it's with Catra.

It's interesting enough to just watch Catra's ears flick and her tail sway occasionally, regardless of what is going on below them. As long as it's interesting enough to keep Catra there, it's good enough for Adora too.

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Catra and Adora wrestle. Not in a combat-training-way, but just in a *let's have fun* way. A lot of them used to wrestle when they were really little, but Adora or Catra were usually the instigators – actually, if Adora thinks back far enough, Catra was the one who introduced Adora to the joys of it in the first place, so really she's the instigator of it all – and now the others don't usually want to do it anymore. Adora has tried, once or twice, but Rogelio only does it half-heartedly and Lonnie turns it into actual combat training. Not that Adora *isn't* training, in a way, when she wrestles Catra, but that's more of a benefit than the point.

Wrestling like wasn't even worth her time, so that just leaves her and Catra. Catra has always been the most fun to wrestle anyway. It's her game, after all, of course she's the best at it. Catra will tumble with Adora across the training hall floor – or the gym, or the locker room, or the bunk room depending on where one of them decided the only recourse was to pounce on the other – as they struggle with each other for dominance, sometimes pulling on each other's hair but never fighting for their lives like they do in training.

It's *fun*, one of many fun things that are just for the two of them, and it's even something allowable, because if nothing else it helps them train their muscles in ways training doesn't always hit. Sure, they get yelled at if they do it somewhere inconvenient, but it isn't like the cuddle sessions that they've been subtly encouraged to stop.

When Adora notices Catra's tail lashing, she knows what's coming. Catra's tail lashes for a lot of reasons, in a lot of ways – slow and powerful or frantic and excitable – but it's a certain *way* her tail moves that tips Adora off. It's fast, without too much power to it and nothing else in her body to indicate nerves. Adora hasn't said anything to earn a pounce – most often this happens after some

teasing – but she's still prepared when Catra suddenly launches at her. She twists and meets her, and then they go rolling across the floor together as Adora tries to grab Catra's wrists.

Catra bypasses hers entirely, grabbing her shoulders and trying to wrap her legs around her in a way that can pin her down. Adora arches her hips and scrabbles trying to get her feet under her so Catra can't pin her, but that leaves her unbalanced and gives Catra an opportunity to pitch them to the side again. They keep rolling until they hit the wall, Adora at the disadvantage on her back again with her shoulder pinned against the wall.

Catra growls, light and excited. Adora *loves* that sound. She growls back, a poor imitation that just kind of sounds like she has something stuck in her throat and doesn't vibrate the way Catra's does, a tingle in the air that always dances across her skin. It makes Catra respond though, baring her teeth at Adora, so it's good enough. Adora twists her grin into a reflection of the expression, even if she doesn't have the fangs to show off that Catra does. It probably looks stupid, but she doesn't care. Regardless of their posturing, both of them are grinning, really.

"Catra! Adora!" Shadow Weaver's voice snaps down the hall. Suddenly the growling – the *laughter* – is gone. Both of them scramble to disentangle themselves, Catra springing up to her feet first and Adora following a moment later with a salute. Shadow Weaver stands at the end of the hall, just having rounded the corner. Beside Adora, Catra's tail sways behind her, unsure and nervous.

"We were practicing grappling," Adora volunteers, voice breathless. Shadow Weaver's eyes narrow. She turns her head slightly, fixing her gaze on Catra instead. Catra's tail does that same unsure wave again and her ears pin back.

"You're always saying that we need to be ready. I was testing Adora's reaction time," she adds, voice strong despite how nervous Adora *knows* she is. Shadow Weaver doesn't seem impressed.

"There is no excuse for infecting Adora with your *tendencies*. Better is expected of her than acting like you. Control yourself," she instructs. Adora's heart falls, but before she can process that, Shadow Weaver fixes her gaze on her instead. "And you, control *her*. If you ever want to be a leader and prove your worth to Horde-Prime, you must have command of both yourself and those beneath you."

Actually, Adora was under *Catra* just then, halfway to bested, but she hangs her head feeling the appropriate shame, even if she doesn't quite know what for. She thinks it was the growling. Shadow Weaver doesn't like it when she does that, even if she tends to let it slide from Catra – depending on who she's aiming it at. Adora draws in a breath as Shadow Weaver sweeps forward to stand over them.

"I expect a lot of you, Adora. Don't fail me," Shadow Weaver adds. Her voice isn't *soft* – Adora knows what soft is from when Catra whispers to her – but it *is* softer, Shadow Weaver's version of gentle. It's the guiding touch that reminds Adora it's worth it to keep trying to decode the rules. Once she has figured out when – and why – some things that seem conditional are okay, it will be easier to follow them and not get anyone in trouble.

When Shadow Weaver is looking, anyway. If wrestling is the part Shadow Weaver has a problem with, Adora isn't intending to stop fully. Actually, she isn't going to stop the growling either, but she doesn't do it all that much anymore anyway so she thinks that won't be too much of a problem. She doesn't know how she's supposed to just stop touching Catra. She *likes* messing around with her, and even if it isn't real training, she still thinks it has benefits.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver. I won't," Adora promises, her voice quiet. Shadow Weaver straightens above her. Her shadow inclines its head, and then she sweeps past the two of them. Adora holds her breath until the aura that follows Shadow Weaver dissipates. She glances back over her shoulder and, finding the coast clear, blows out the air she was holding in her too-full chest. Her shoulders fall with it as she finally looks to Catra, shooting her an apologetic look. She's pretty sure that was all her fault. Catra lets out a *tch*, looking

away and crossing her arms. Her tail is flicking. Irritation; Adora usually knows that one when she sees it.

"Whatever . She only interrupted because I was making you look bad," Catra says, but despite her dismissal, her voice is low . She doesn't want to be overheard again. Adora huffs out a laugh, nothing deep or genuine, but some of the stress releases from her chest with it as she reaches up and pushes some flyaways out of her eyes.

"Yeah, right. You hadn't won yet," Adora returns, nudging her shoulder and then walking forward. She would like to leave the hallway now. She already knows she is going to feel a twinge of guilt when she walks through it for the next few days. Catra scoffs, looking back towards her to send her a smug look.

"But I *was* going to," she corrects. That kind of statement would usually be met with Adora making a bid to grab her to prove her wrong and Catra either dancing away or *meeting* her, starting a proper wrestle.

Instead, Adora laughs and shoves at her shoulder . They are going to wrestle again, and likely soon, but better not to disobey Shadow Weaver *immediately*.

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It takes Adora way too long to figure it out. It's Lonnie who says it in the end, casually and in passing while Adora is sulking after training.

"I just don't know why Catra is allowed to but I'm not." She never got *over* the growling thing, alright. She's even less over purring, but she knows Catra doesn't like to acknowledge that she can even do that for herself, so she never grouses about it. They were training against each other with staves today, and when Rogelio bared down on her

–he' s *big* and hard to fight head-on, or in general –Adora snarled at him. Cobalt basically called her weird afterwards when he was going over their scores. She's almost certain Catra did it a few times too, but no one said anything to her. t sounds better when Catra does it, but Adora *knows* that's not the reason he mentioned it.

"Because magicats growl and humans dont, duh," Lonnie says, rolling her eyes as she tugs a cold towel in place over her neck both to cool off and soothe the bruise she got when Catra threw her. Adora, facing into her locker with her face thankfully hidden, blinks.

"I Iknow that. Iknew that!" she didnt, "But why does it matter?" she replies, voice high, but it's finally occurring to her that all those words people say sometimes –things like magicat, and lizardfolk, and human –arent just general descriptors like *blonde* or *short*. They actually mean something. And yes, she kind of knew that, but it never really clicked until this moment.

She and Catra arent the same at *all*. They arent the same race, and now that Adora is thinking about it, they definitely arent just dif ferent in the ways that her and Lonnie are different. When she was little, she used to wonder why Catra got to be so cute and soft and agile. Not that she necessarily wanted to be just like that herself, but it wasnt some perfect luck coming together to make Catra the way she is: Adora never had a chance.

"D ferent biology, different standards. Not sure why he even notices at this point when it's you, though," Lonnie says, completely nonchalant, unbothered. When Adora turns around, Lonnie is in the middle of shrugging and looks bored. Rogelio is shooting Adora a *look* that she absolutely isnt acknowledging. She' s just lucky that Catra got stuck with supply duty after training today. Usually she doesnt like when they end up on dif ferent rotations, but she's really glad Catra isnt here for this conversation because she has all those fancy senses and would probably be able to tell what's going on with Adora.

Again, she is *not* looking Rogelio's way.

t's a *double* standard,"Adora shoots back, crossing her arms. Continuing her sulk is probably her only chance to maintain some illusion of understanding a fact which it is dawning on her more and more is definitely basic knowledge that she should have grasped much earlier. She has known the words *human* and *lizardfolk* all her life. Magicat is written on Catra's file and she has seen it several times. It just never meant all that much to her. That's just how to describe someone who looks like Catra, she thought, not *what she was*.

No wonder she can't growl.

Lonnie laughs at her, almost as if she can hear her thoughts. Adora is *definitely* grateful that she can't, though, because she would be laughing a lot harder if so. She takes a moment to be grateful for the fact that no race can read minds, and then she takes another moment to panic that one *can* and she just doesn't know about it because she didn't realize races even mattered before today.

"Only you would be upset by this. I just want her to stop growling at me when I breathe the wrong way," Lonnie says. Adora pouts. Catra doesn't growl for no reason, she just has a bit of a *thing* about Lonnie and neither of them is blameless in that. Adora and even Kyle have had to mediate fights between them before. Then again, Kyle has had to mediate fights between all the members of the squad, including her and Catra. He mostly just begs from the sidelines for everybody to take a breath and tries to distract them, but even with how ineffective that often is, it might be his most important contribution to the squad when it works.

Adora is too busy having a revelation to explain the nuances of Catra's growls, though – especially since sometimes it really is for no discernable reason – so she turns back around to close her locker. She needs to make an excuse and get out of here. She's pretty sure she has a lot of processing to do.

--

Okay, so. Maybe. *Maybe* it does turn out that none of the humans except Adora growl. Maybe, she has noticed, no one else pesters Rogelio or even Catra by playing with their tail anymore. Sure, occasionally Lonnie or someone will get mad and grab Catra's tail while she's turning away from them, but no one *plays* with tails anymore. Except Adora, sitting beside Catra and grabbing at it whenever it slips away from her, a game of keep-away with the added benefit of getting to pet and *be* pet in process.

It takes her months to realize all the small things her… misunderstanding effects, and honestly she never *stops* realizing because there's always some memory lurking in her subconscious that is thrown in stark relief by her new knowledge. She is paying attention now and suddenly a lot of things that used to confuse her click.

Kind of. Like, she gets it, they're different. But why do they have to be, actually? She's never going to have ears and a tail or Catra's vocal chords, but she doesn't know why it's a problem for her to head bump Catra back – it isn't cuddling anymore and surely that's enough – or for her to wrestle with Catra, or for her to bite people while fighting, even if it's kind of unsanitary. Adora maintains that biting people in battle *works*, and why wouldn't she use every tool she has available? That's just bad tactics.

The things they do are fun, they come naturally to her at this point, and even if they didn't, she likes things that she and Catra share. So it makes her weird; it's *theirs* and they don't get a lot of things that are just theirs. When she first found out it was "wrong," she felt embarrassed and kind of stupid. Maybe she's just trying to assuage that embarrassment, but now she decides that she isn't just okay with it, but she's *proud* of it. Now that she knows, she can be a little more "normal" around others, but she can still enjoy herself with Catra.

t feels more fleeting now , but she chases those snatches of *something* whenever she gets a chance, an emotion she has never been given a name for but that kind of hurts and yet she cant turn away from bubbling up. When Catra's tail brushes against her hand as they pass each other in the hall, the expression on Catra' s face grim and Shadow Weaver's hand tight on Adora's shoulder as she leads her away for what is probably going to be another inspirational talk that makes it hard to breathe as she tries to figure out how she can live up to everything the Horde needs her to be, all she wants to do is turn around and grab Catra's tail back, pulling on it until Catra stops so Adora can throw herself at her and squeeze her close to her chest. t would be easier to breathe with her face buried in Catra's ears, pricked up and swiveling back after her as she passes.

Instead she gets a brief brush of softness and a small noise of displeasure from Shadow Weaver that has her fixing her eyes forward with determination. She cant be distracted. Shadow W eaver is always saying that. t just makes a bad soldier . She might be a bad human, but she will make herself a good soldier. Her friendship with Catra doesnt compromise that, and one day shell convince everyone else of that too, but for now she looks forward.

--

She was right that she never stops having those little realizations, but they certainly slow down a lot, at least for a few years. Leaving the Horde brings with it an all-new set of realizations and magicat-based ones are still counted amongst their ranks, but it's lower on the list of priorities. She flounders through finding her way in a non-military based society enough that her Catra-based idiosyncrasies are far from her most glaring problem.

Glimmer jokes about her being a little feral here and there, but aside from maybe giving the Princess Alliance a slightly warped perception

of what is typical for a Horde soldier, she manages. Barely, but that's for a lot of reasons and has very little to do with the fact that she didn't realize she was human for a solid chunk of her childhood. Or that being human mattered, whatever. It feels like getting a limb back when Catra returns to her life. It feels *right* to bump Catra's shoulder, only for Catra to bump her back, and then Adora to bump back harder until they're wrestling on the floor like they're kids again.

Sure, Glimmer is sighing and Bow is saying, "Really, guys? At breakfast?" but that doesn't *matter* because Adora comes out on top and she gets to grin down at Catra. Despite being pinned beneath Adora – like, actually pinned because they don't even do play fights by half-measures, though this is far from their brawls in the war – Catra smiles back. They're both panting and Adora *swears* she hears the vibrations of that elusive purr on Catra's breath. It's the kind of joy that would feel breathless even if they hadn't just gone rolling across the floor with Melog batting at their backs cautiously as if unsure how – or if they should try – to join in on the play.

So Adora kisses Catra, because she can *do* that now that it's just a few days after everything fell apart and came together. It's not as profound as the first time but it's definitely still as profound as the fifth or whatever else. She *loves* feeling Catra's purr against her chest as she drapes over her, the rolling vibrations far more important than Glimmer protesting behind them.

"Not in front of my dad!"

"And what about you?" Micah's laughing, apparently having a better sense of humor this early in the morning than his daughter, but Adora's a little lost in Catra's purr, even as the kiss slows to a stop and leaves them with their faces close together, Catra nuzzling at her cheek and the air buzzing around them. Adora is even more breathless now.

"I saw worse before the first day was up," Glimmer replies, volume rising pointedly in a way that's definitely intended to shame them, but when Adora pulls away it's only so there can be enough distance

between them for her to look into Catra's eyes. Her pupils are round, and Adora knows now that *definitely* isn't just because they're close together or whatever she thought when they were six. Well, it's certainly because they're *close*, but physical distance has nothing to do with it.

Every little thing about Catra that she ever thought she was jealous of- yeah, that's *not* what that emotion was, but now she gets to reach up and frame the bases of Catra's ears to gently massage them, satisfying all those times she wanted to touch them but couldn't find a reason, so whatever. She intends to lean in and kiss her as she strokes her fingers through the softness, but Catra groans and flutters her eyes closed, tipping her head back into the attention. All those times Adora held herself back and it turns out Catra *loves* her ears being pet.

"Guys!" Okay, now Glimmer's tone is embarrassed and chastising enough for Adora to halt her touch and send Catra an apologetic smile when she opens her eyes with them already narrowing up at Adora in annoyance. It was innocent, but it definitely didn't sound like it, and she is kind of straddling Catra on the floor of the dining room, so she gets it. She shifts her hands to frame Catra's head so she can tilt it up to place a kiss between her ears instead.

"You can have ear scritchies after we finish work," Adora promises her as she reluctantly disentangles herself from her girlfriend. Catra scoffs as she stands up, sulking beside Adora. She still holds her hand as they walk back to their chairs, askew at the table.

"That's going to take all day," she complains. Adora laughs as she pulls Catra's chair out for her. Catra blushes, and wow isn't that a pretty sight, but she drops down into it without further complaint and lets Adora nudge her seat back into place at the table. Within a moment of Adora sitting down for herself, a significantly smaller-than-average Melog jumps up into her lap and looks up at her with the same wide eyes Catra sent her when they were on the floor.

Adora grins, sending Catra a smug look that Catra ignores by pretending to be very interested in what's happening outside a window on the opposite side of the room. Adora isn't fooled. She can feel the tell-tale tingle of a purr in the air when she drops a hand to pet over Melog as she returns to breakfast. She's grinning far too brightly for this early in the morning according to the disgusted look Glimmer sends her, but she doesn't care. She's happy, and with Catra by her side, she's *free* in a way she has never really been before.

They can be them however they want. Adora can be weird all she wants, and *in love*, which she certainly never got to be in the Horde. Her old squad's desensitization to her weirdness has nothing on being able to *kiss Catra* while she's purring. Besides, the Princess Alliance is just as desensitized at this point too. She doesn't have to compromise now – she can just be all the things that make her happy, she can actually care about what those are, and most of all she can be with Catra.

It's a dream that didn't feel possible when they were kids.

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The Princess Alliance is not, in fact, totally desensitized, but to be fair that's probably because she gets "weirder" now Catra is back at her side. It's more like she lets go of the voice in the back of her head – she knows *exactly* who it sounds like – that always hisses at her to fall in line and play her part. There's nothing different about her really, she was always like this, she just stops holding herself back.

Sure, it probably shows how much she isn't listening when she reaches out in the middle of a meeting to brush Catra's bangs back from her eyes and gives a rolling scratch down her jaw – *are you*

even listening, Mermista says, and Adora is too busy grinning at Catra leaning into her touch and fluttering her eyes to reply – but she is still struggling with letting her old chains go, so moments like this feel *incredible* and she doesn't have an ounce of shame about them when she manages to lay her burdens down enough to let them happen in the first place. Catra's blush says she's at least embarrassed, but she also leans into it, so clearly she likes it more than she minds the eyes on them.

"Remember when Shadow Weaver would reprimand *me* every time you growled?" Catra says one day, rolling her eyes as she takes Adora's weight from her so she can breathe for a minute. Adora might have growled through her last two reps, but she swears it helps her push through when it feels like her muscles can't keep going. Working out helps level her out when she starts feeling like there's a fight somewhere she's missing – peace is *way harder* than she gave it credit for – and she isn't about to go easy on it and let herself fall out of shape. It might be vanity as much as it is paranoia, but she wants to keep the muscle she has. Maybe gain a bit more. She-ra's muscles just *happen*, magic and all that, but she'd like to have them without having to be seven feet tall. Catra only lets She-ra pick her up some of the time, and she prefers her as Adora.

Most of the time. There's always exceptions. Besides, if she works out more as Adora, maybe She-ra's muscles will get bigger. That would be cool.

"As if I wasn't always trying to mirror you?" Yeah," Adora replies, still winded. She watches Catra's ears twitch, and then she looks down at her. Round pupils, Adora notices with a smile creeping up her face. She's a little cockier than usual when she has the endorphins of a workout trickling through her.

"Everybody thought you were weird," Catra says back, words not quite coming out slow, but there's a *purposeful* way to how she says them. From several feet away, Glimmer barks a laugh as Adora shrugs, unbothered.

"She's like that from growing up with you, huh?" Glimmer comments dryly from where she's sitting on a bench and not even working out. Bow doesn't need a spotter right now, but Glimmer has just been watching him ever since he started his reps. Catra laughs and Adora grunts—it's a better mimic of a chuff than the old cough she used to do, even if it doesn't sound any closer—and reaches up for her weight again.

"I thought Catra was the coolest person ever and didn't realize yet that I wasn't going to be able to *learn* purring," Adora replies, grabbing at the air in a blatant request for the weight back. Catra is watching her *very keenly* with her eyes round, so she shouldn't be missing it, but she is very focused on Adora's face right now. Adora sends Catra her brightest grin, a *please* that Catra eventually listens to, lowering the weight back into her hands as Glimmer laughs again in the background. Even Bow huffs something like a laugh with the movement of his next rep.

"Wow, you really liked me, how embarrassing," Catra says, because they can always tease each other even if she clearly cares about Adora's words far more than her banter implies. She's sending Adora a smug smirk, but around the edges of it she's still *looking* at her in a way that tells Adora they're probably going to be leaving the gym soon and Melog will not be following them.

"Loved you," Adora corrects, voice a bit strained as she pushes the weight back up away from her chest again. "It doesn't matter –" Catra's eyes turn to slits, narrowing in on her, and while Adora normally associates Catra's eyes dilating with her relaxing with her, *loving* her, she knows that look, and it's one of a hunter.

Adora made her want to pounce. She grins as she does another rep, no need to growl to push through. She's more than happy to flex for Catra until this workout is over. She has a feeling she isn't going to get the opportunity to shower for a while after they leave here.

End Notes

Codename: the furry Adora fic. Lol, really it's just because a long time ago I had a line in some fic about Adora not realizing they were different species until they were older and that became a joke in my head about Adora not understanding why she didn't end up with anything cool like claws. It's really unfair guys :(This became more about her being secretly (to herself, anyway) gay when I went to write it tho.
I've had this idea for ages but I'd be lying if I said this art didn't inspire me to actually start it (yes, I know how long ago I reblogged it. I've literally had the tab open ever since waiting, and I switched to it whenever I needed a boost of motivation to work on this). Also Meta has a great comic in a similar vein. And wow you can tell how long I've been thinking about this because I talked about that line in the tags too XD

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